

This essay is a structured adaptation of arguments originally developed in an online thread by Rjrasva (July 2021). The thread presented the ideas in an informal and conversational format and includes extensive citations and exchanges with other participants. The present text reorganizes that material into a continuous analytical essay while preserving the core argument. Readers interested in the original discussion and its supporting references can consult the thread here: <https://x.com/Rjrasva/status/1412388808482508810>.

Strategic Blindness in Pre-modern India

A persistent question confronts any serious student of Indian history: why did the subcontinent's ruling and commercial classes fail, repeatedly and catastrophically, to process available information about external threats into coherent strategic responses? This failure was not one of information access. Indian merchants, diplomats, and travelers were present across every geography where the relevant transformations were occurring. The failure was institutional. Mechanisms for converting that presence into usable strategic intelligence simply did not exist.

The Case of the Rashtrakutas and the Rise of Islam

The standard defence offered for the Rashtrakutas and their contemporaries is that tenth-century Indian rulers could not have known about Islam or anticipated its consequences. Even minimal scrutiny collapses this argument. The relevant facts were available to anyone paying attention. Sindh had fallen to the Arab armies two hundred years before al-Masudi was writing. The kingdoms of Kabul and Zabul were under continuous Islamic military pressure. The Sassanid empire, India's immediate northwestern civilizational neighbor across centuries of cultural and commercial exchange, had been destroyed nearly two hundred and sixty years earlier.

The argument from ignorance is further undermined by the documented presence of Indian merchants across precisely the geographies where these transformations were occurring. These merchants were literate and connected to networks at home. They left Sanskrit inscriptions in Socotra, on the island of Yemen, attesting to their presence along the southwestern Arabian trade routes. Yet not a single record survives, in text or inscription, from the Indian side that records the fall of the Sassanids, the conquest of Sindh, or the ongoing jihad campaigns against Kabul, nor any record that draws conclusions from these events for the security of the subcontinent.

The absence may not be total. Records may have existed and been lost. But the pattern of absence is too systematic to be explained by archival accident alone. The dhando uncles of antiquity were trading in Iran, Arabia, and along the Red Sea littoral. They did not see fit to record the rise of Mohammedanism or warn their countrymen of the coming storm. Ibn Battuta's fourteenth-century account of Kerala's accommodation of Muslim settlers, including the dhimmitude of the Hindu kings, the mosques, and the administrative posts extended to Muslim merchants, records a pattern of institutional complacency that the Rashtrakuta evidence suggests had already been established centuries earlier.

The Gujarat case under Siddharaja Jayasimha is the most telling. A Muslim merchant felt sufficiently confident in local ignorance or indifference to place an Arabic inscription praying for jihadi conquest directly beside his own Sanskrit inscription expressing gratitude to his Hindu hosts. This is not the behavior of a man who believes the local rulers understand the ideological content of the faith he practices. His confidence was justified. When Parsis, refugees who had fled precisely the civilizational destruction that the inscription was celebrating, instigated locals to destroy the minaret and burn the mosque, Siddharaja responded by punishing the Parsis and the Hindu communities alongside them. He awarded the Muslim complainants one lakh Balotras in silver to rebuild the structure and presented the complainant with four articles of dress as personal compensation.

This same Siddharaja built the Rudramahalaya, said to be fourteen stories high and one of the largest temple complexes ever constructed. Ulugh Khan raided and damaged it. Ahmed Shah obliterated what remained. The pattern is complete. The same ruler who funded Islamic institutional infrastructure and punished those who resisted its expansion also built the greatest monument of his civilization, a monument that was subsequently destroyed by the beneficiaries of his accommodation.

S. R. Goel's summary of the situation is accurate as far as it goes. Only a state and a population that did not know or understand the tenets of Islam and the obligations those tenets imposed upon every Muslim could permit these settlements in its leading cities and ports. But the more precise formulation is institutional rather than purely epistemic. The information was available. The institutions for processing it into strategic knowledge did not exist.

The Indian Exceptions and What They Reveal

Two exceptions to the Indian pattern of strategic blindness are documented. Both are known exclusively from non-Indian records, which is itself the most damning detail in the entire account.

The Pallava monarch Rajasimha offered military aid to China against the Arabs and Tibetans. This demonstrates genuine strategic awareness of the highest order: a South Indian ruler understood the geopolitical situation well enough to identify an alliance opportunity against a common threat. This episode is known from Chinese records. No Indian inscription or text records it.

Bhaskaravarman of Kamarupa requested that the Dao De Jing be translated into Sanskrit. The translation was completed under Emperor Taizong and brought to India by Xuanzang. A ruler on the northeastern frontier of the subcontinent was actively importing Chinese philosophical texts. This episode too is known only from Chinese records.

The Parsis arrived on Indian shores as refugees from the precise civilizational destruction that Islamic expansion had inflicted on Iran. They were direct witnesses to

the consequences of conquest. Whatever interrogation of their experience occurred, and some interrogation must have occurred, produced no surviving Indian record. The *vayadm pārasīkam* material that exists comes from Parsi records rather than from the Indian hosts who received them.

Across all three cases the pattern is consistent. Awareness existed in individual instances. The institutional mechanism required to convert that awareness into transmissible strategic knowledge, to preserve it in the administrative record, and to make it available to later rulers and merchants confronting the same challenges did not exist.

The Japanese Contrast

The systematic nature of the Indian failure becomes fully visible only in comparative perspective. Premodern Japan provides the sharpest available contrast. This is not because Japan lacked its own failures, but because its institutional responses to external threats were consistently more intelligent, more anticipatory, and more effectively organized across comparable situations.

After the collapse of the Yamato-Paekche alliance against the Silla-Tang coalition in the seventh century, Japan maintained continuous military vigilance in Kyushu for nearly four centuries in anticipation of an invasion that never came. The threat posed by Silla contributed directly to the consolidation of Japan's martial tradition by forcing the state to maintain long-term preparedness. The institutional memory of strategic defeat was converted into sustained vigilance rather than buried or rationalized away.

When the Mongols rose to continental dominance, Japanese residents in Korea sent detailed reports back to the home islands. The shogunate possessed advance intelligence about the Mongol conquest of Korea and was preparing its response before the invasion fleets appeared. When the Manchus conquered the Ming, the Japanese court debated whether to respond to Ming appeals for assistance and help restore the loyalists. Such a debate required serious knowledge of continental Chinese politics and the capacity to evaluate what Manchu consolidation would mean for Japan's strategic position.

The institutional mechanism that supported these responses was explicit and formal. The Tokugawa shogunate required the Dutch trading station at Nagasaki to submit annual reports on developments outside Japan. The Dutch complied, supplying detailed information on global affairs. Shogunal officials also conducted extensive interviews with Dutch representatives during each of their stays in Edo. These interviews lasted four to five hours and involved systematic questioning about foreign politics and the movements of external powers. The shogunate had effectively converted its commercial relationship with the Dutch into a structured intelligence operation.

By 1818–1819 Vasily Golovnin was recording that the Japanese elite were explicitly concerned about the rise of English power in India. The British consolidation of the subcontinent generated genuine strategic anxiety in Tokyo because Japanese officials feared that Japan could be the next target of expansion. A political transformation

occurring on the other side of Asia was being monitored and assessed for its implications, while the Indian subcontinent itself produced no comparable analytical response.

The text *Shinron* (“New Theses”) by Aizawa Seishisai, written in 1825, represents the most striking example of this contrast. Aizawa wrote without access to the Quran or the Hadith and without the theological knowledge that would have been available to educated Indian Muslims or to Hindu scholars who had studied Islamic civilization. His analysis relied entirely on strategic observation, particularly the intelligence gathered through Dutch reports. Yet the geopolitical analysis he produced of Islamic civilization, including its expansionary logic, institutional cohesion, and relationship to subject populations, proved more practically useful than anything generated within the Indian intellectual tradition during the entire period of Islamic expansion into the subcontinent.

The earliest Japanese biography of Peter the Great appeared in 1805, sixty-three years before the Meiji Restoration. It was written in response to Russian expansion reaching Hokkaido. Japanese intellectuals read whatever information they could obtain about Russia and analyzed the implications of Peter's transformation of that country into a great power. Most remarkably, they began to treat Peter as a possible model for Japan's own transformation. The analysis of a foreign ruler's methods was converted into domestic developmental strategy six decades before the Meiji state implemented that strategy.

The Diagnostic and Its Contemporary Application

The diagnostic suggested by this history is institutional rather than civilizational. Indian commercial and intellectual networks possessed the necessary geographic reach. Information existed. What was missing was the equivalent of the Dutch reports: a formal mechanism that converted commercial contact and diplomatic interaction into structured strategic intelligence available to decision-makers. What was missing was the equivalent of an Aizawa: an intellectual formation willing to ask, of any major external development, what it meant for one's own civilization and to pursue the answer regardless of whether the sources were domestically familiar.

Mohan Lal Kashmiri, who traveled through Central Asia in the nineteenth century and kept detailed records later published as memoirs, demonstrates that the tradition possessed the necessary intellectual capacity. He produced strategic intelligence. The problem is that he did so for British institutions rather than for Indian ones. The individual capable of generating strategic analysis existed. The institution capable of directing that analysis toward Indian interests did not.

The contemporary inheritance of this failure is visible in the near-total absence of serious Indian scholarship on Chinese history, Chinese strategic thought, or Chinese institutional development. The number of serious Indian scholars in this field can be counted on the fingers of one hand. Raghuvira and his son Lokeshchandra remain among the most distinguished examples. No serious Hindi-language biography exists of

Qin Shi Huangdi, the ruler who unified China under Legalist principles and created the institutional template that Chinese statecraft has drawn upon for two millennia. No serious Hindi-language biography exists of the Qianlong Emperor, under whose rule Chinese power reached India's borders and whose forces attempted to conquer Nepal during the Nepal-Tibet conflict. That episode represented a direct strategic engagement with the subcontinent, yet it generated almost no analytical response in India then and almost none since.

Indian travelers were present in the Qing empire, as Chinese records attest. They did not produce strategic analyses of Qing policies affecting their homeland any more than the Socotra merchants produced analyses of the Islamic expansion unfolding around them. The intellectual energy that should be developing such analytical capacity is instead consumed by subcaste hierarchy disputes, regional language supremacy debates, and other forms of internal identity politics that have no strategic relevance to external challenges. The Rashtrakuta merchants' failure to record the fall of the Sassanids is now replicated by scholars who should be studying the *Book of Lord Shang* and producing the first serious Indian-language analyses of Chinese statecraft but instead devote their efforts to disputes about which community's ancestors were more authentically ancient.

The corrective is easy to describe but difficult to institutionalize. One must take a sustained interest in the outside world and read the foundational texts of civilizations that have demonstrated the capacity for strategic intelligence. A starting point is the *Book of Lord Shang*, the central text of Chinese Legalism. It is available in translation and describes with remarkable clarity the institutional mechanisms through which a state builds the capacity to survive in a competitive multistate environment. It should be read alongside the *Arthashastra*. The differences between the two texts should be analyzed. The consequences those differences produced over two millennia of history should be assessed. From that assessment one can begin to ask what institutional changes would be required to create the equivalent of the Dutch reports for the present century.

The Socotra inscriptions remain. The merchants who carved them did not warn their countrymen. That absence, whether the result of choice or institutional incapacity, has compounded for fourteen centuries. The question now is whether the compounding can be interrupted.